

# Class 9: Politically Violent Activity

Escalation and restraint

Dr. Michael C. Zeller

# Agenda for the day

- Opening notes
- Antifa
- Poll: escalation and restraint
- Mechanisms of escalation and restraint
- Open data - Profiles of Radicalisation
- A case of RWE restraint?
- Any questions, concerns, feedback for this class?

# Opening notes



## Presentations line-up

| Date    | Presenters                           | Method           |
|---------|--------------------------------------|------------------|
| 4 Dec:  | Shahadaan, Kristine, Daichi          | ethnography      |
| 11 Dec: | Bérénice, Zorka, Victoria, Katharina | content analysis |
| 18 Dec: | Shoam, Aidan, Tara, Sebastian        | QCA              |

# Antifa

- opening discussion
- debatable proposition and pressing policy issue
- antifa in Germany
- Copsey and Merrill (2020): antifa in the U.S.



What should we, students of political violence, know about *antifa*? (causes? organisation/leadership? radical subcultures and mobilisation? strategies?)

is antifa a 'gang' (Pyrooz and Densley 2018)? is antifa a 'group' (LaFree 2018)?

- **gang** - 'durable and street-oriented youth group whose involvement in illegal activity is part of its group identity' (Pyrooz and Densley 2018, 230)
- **group** - 'some stable organisation that persists over time and has some discernible leadership structure' (LaFree 2018, 249), see also GTF database: <https://www.start.umd.edu/gtd/>

# Debatable proposition: antifa as terrorist org.?

Pyrooz and Densley (2018, 233): “the history of antifa reads like a history of violence”

VS.

Bray (2017, 169): “In truth, violence represents a small though vital sliver of anti-fascist activity.”

Should state security (in Germany, elsewhere) designate antifa as *extremist/terrorist*

# antifa (recently) in Germany

ARD series (in German): <https://www.ardaudiothek.de/sendung/die-fascho-jaegerin-der-fall-lina-e-und-seine-folgen/94838298/>

- 28-year-old antifa activist, Lina E., and three accomplices jailed for either membership of or support for a criminal organisation.
  - politicised/radicalised by revelations about NSU in 2011
- attacks on (assumed) right-wing extremists in Thüringen and Sachsen between 2018 and 2020
- judge...
  - acknowledged deficiency of criminal punishment of neo-Nazis
  - described right-wing extremism as a greater threat to Germany
  - but asserted 'even Nazis have inalienable rights'
  - criticized the defense lawyers for describing the trial as "political justice."

recent journal article: Jones and Schuhmacher (2024)



# Copsey and Merrill (2020) - background

- Since 2001, **right-wing extremists** in the U.S. responsible for **110 politically motivated deaths** — **antifa: 0** (or maximum one, in case of 2020 death of Patriot Prayer supporter)

In putting their “bodies on the line,” militant anti-fascists aspire to defeat fascist organizing, to de-stabilize it, and ultimately de-mobilize it. At its root, anti-fascist militancy is the promise to effect intimidation, humiliation and de-moralization upon fascists. This involves a physical commitment to “no platforming” (p. 124)

- lots of informative background information about U.S. antifa in the article

# Copsey and Merrill (2020) - research design

# Copsey and Merrill (2020) - findings/points raised

- violent disruption of “fascist” assembly is an axiom of antifa praxis
- how far does the label ‘fascist’ extend?
  - “*legitimacy of anti-fascist action is thus drawn from the illegitimacy of its opponent*”
- antifa’s “pre-emptive self-defence”
  - premised on (a) deadliness of fascist movements of any size and (b) rapid growth potential of fascist movements
- there are ‘*internal tactical* and rhetorical *strategies* that *limit* violence’ from antifa – BUT, consistent danger of antifa slipping into glorification of violence

# Poll: escalation and restraint



Take the survey at

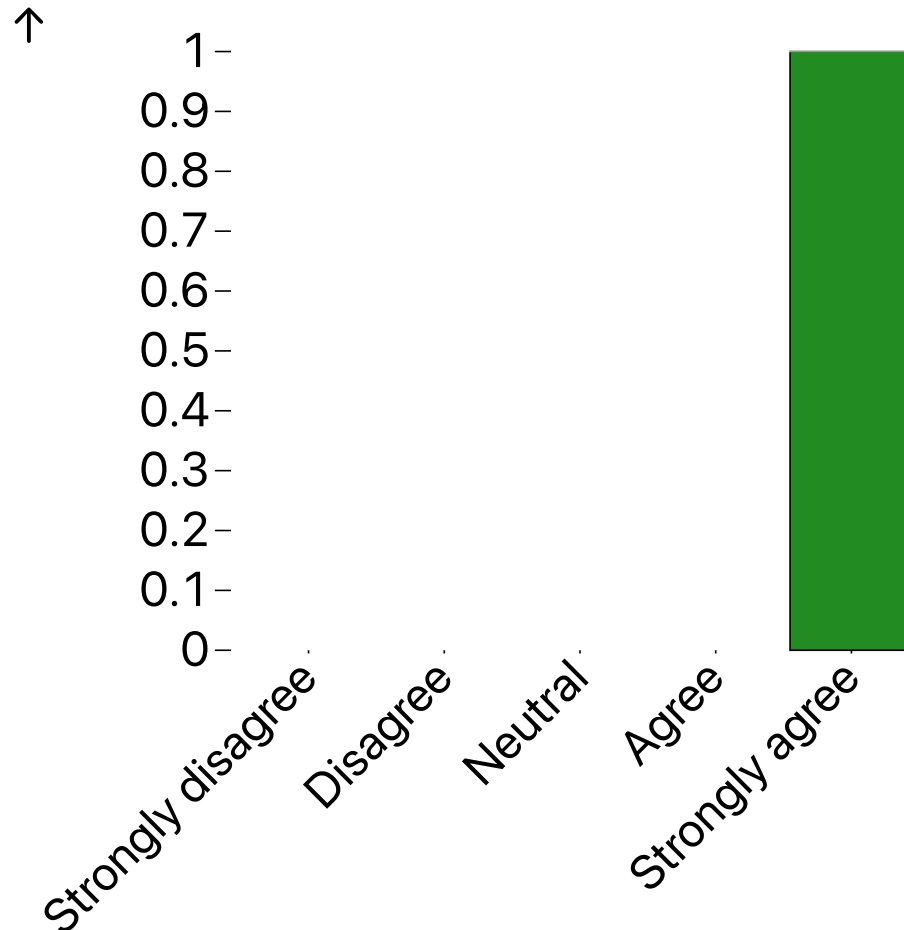
<https://forms.gle/12tV7fgjcAyC8iVG6>

- ideology secondary to pragmatic issues in choosing to use violence?
- most important in allowing *restraint*?
- most likely to provoke *escalation*?
- should states remain open to negotiating with violent groups?
- groups more likely to escalate violence if they feel they are losing support?

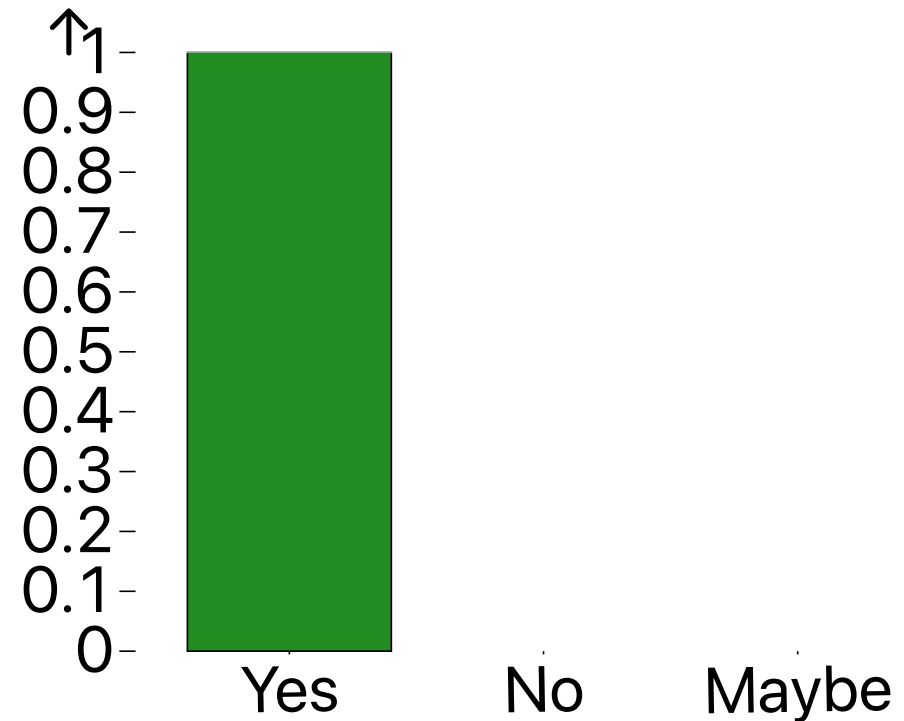
**Questions about groups:** (1) How does the group's use of violence evolve over time? (2) How are major acts of violence perpetrated? (3) Does the group show restraint in choosing targets? (4) Is the group's restraint more strategic or moral? (5) Does the group have internal mechanisms to prevent uncontrolled violence? (6) Does the group escalate violence in response to state actions?

# Poll results (Respondents: 1)

ideology secondary to pragmatic issues?



more likely to escalate if losing support?

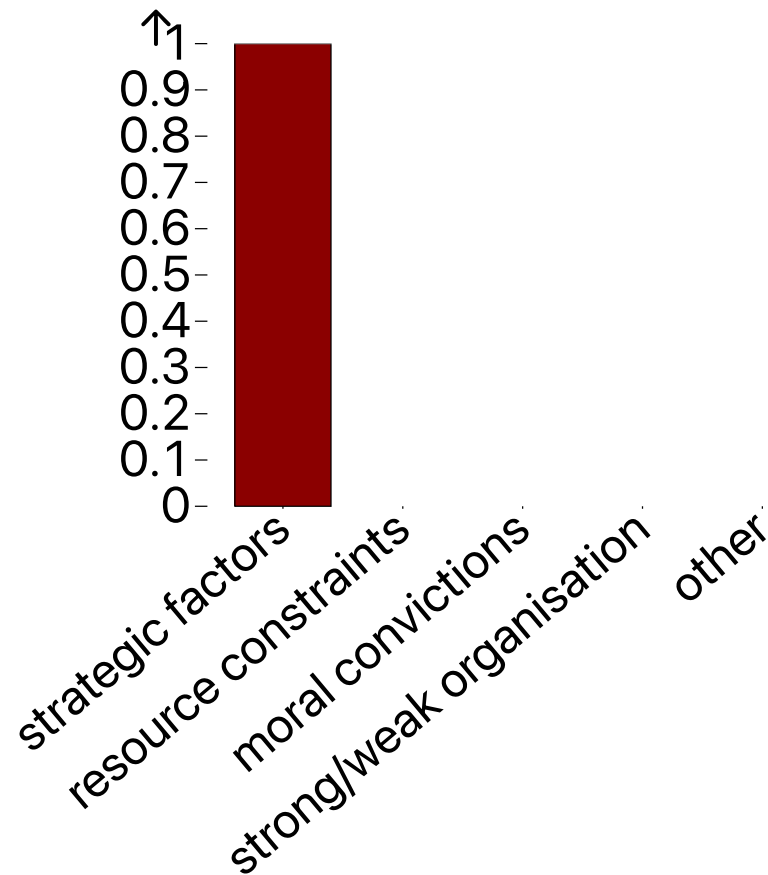




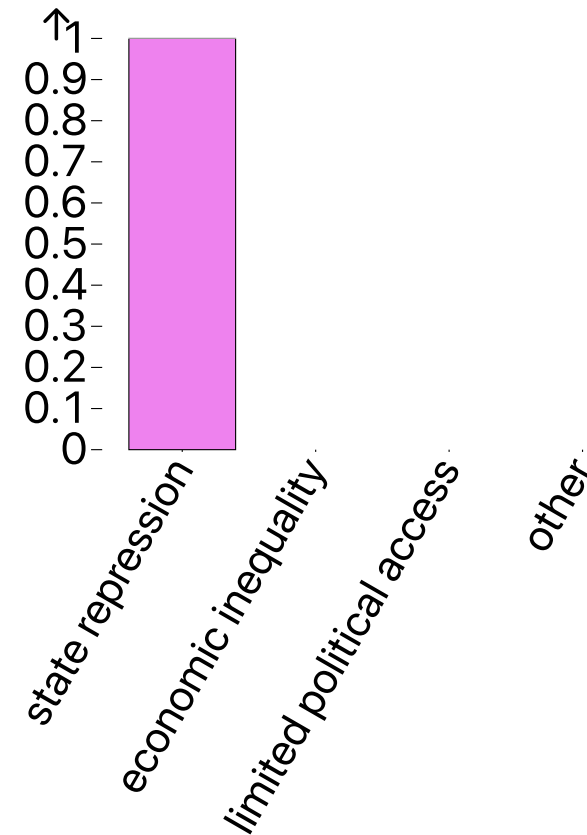


# Poll results: escalation and restraint

most important factor allowing  
*restraint*?



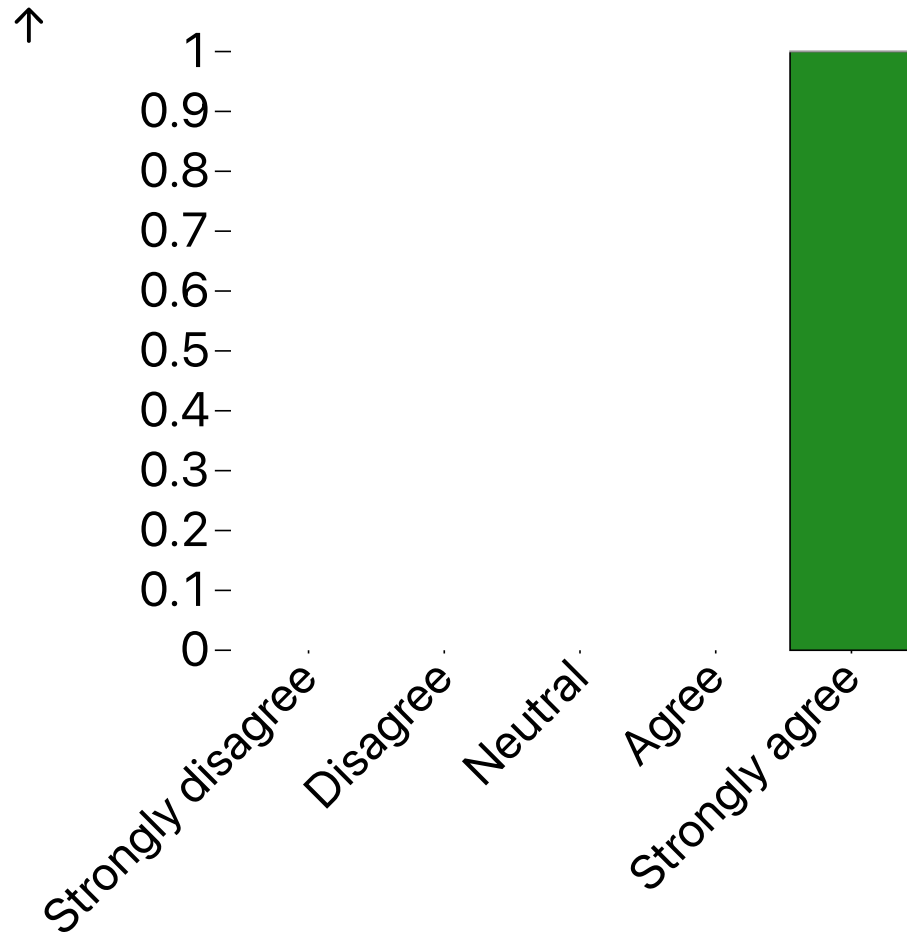
most likely to provoke *escalation*?





# Poll results: negotiation

states should remain open to negotiating with politically violent groups?



relates to our Week 11-12 classes  
on state responses

# Mechanisms of escalation and restraint

- escalation and restraint concepts
- catalogue of mechanisms
- grouped/summarised mechanisms
  - restraint
  - escalation



# escalation and restraint

- **escalation** - a rise in the frequency and/or severity of violent actions
- **restraint** - a deliberate restriction (either reducing or completely stopping) of violent actions

are there significant examples of **escalation** and/or **restraint** in cases you know of?

# Mechanisms of escalation and restraint

| relational arena                     | Violence-enabling mechanisms                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | Violence-inhibiting mechanisms                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|--------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Within movement arena                | A1.1. Intensification of threat narrative<br>A1.2. Foregrounding of revolutionary goals<br>A1.3. Declining influence of moderates<br>A1.4. Valorisation of violence<br>A1.5. Ident. violence as a viable or necessary strategy<br>A1.6. Fear of missing out<br>A1.7. Preparation for violence | B1.1. Campaign/issue deprioritisation or closure<br>B1.2. Foregrounding non-revolutionary goals<br>B1.3. Persistent or expanding influence of moderates<br>B1.4. Disassociation from violence and/or ident. violence as counter-productive<br>B1.5. Rules limiting the use of or opportunities for violence<br>B1.6. Within-movement backlash against violence |
| movement-opposition arena            | A2.1. Increasingly hostile emotional entrainment between activists and their opponents<br>A2.2. Increased mutual expectation of violence<br>A2.3. Increased availability of 'legitimate' targets<br>A2.4. Sudden power imbalance between opposing groups                                      | B2.1. Tactical and/or emotional disentrainment<br>B2.2. Limited expectations of violence<br>B2.3. Steady balance of power within situational contexts<br>B2.4. Achievement of dominance without need for (further) violence                                                                                                                                    |
| movement-political environment arena | A3.1. Diminishing political opportunities<br>A3.2. Growing ident. of 'corrupt elites' as 'the enemy'<br>A3.3. Radical flank actors become the focus of political and/or media attention<br>A3.4. Elites endorse polarising issue frame<br>A3.5. Elites Legitimate violence                    | B3.1. Ways to pursue goals through less extreme means<br>B3.2. Alliance of movement and political or cultural elites<br>B3.3. Elite allies withdraw support in response to rising use or threats of violence by movement actors                                                                                                                                |
| movement-security forces arena       | A4.1. Comm. breakdown between activists and security<br>A4.2. Loss of control by state security actors                                                                                                                                                                                        | B4.1. Open communication between security and activists<br>B4.2. Security forces maintain control (without breaching societal norms of appropriate policing)                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| movement-public arena                | A5.1. Decoupling of movement from general public<br>A5.2. (Part of) public endorse of polarising issue frame<br>A5.3. Legitimation of violence by members of the public                                                                                                                       | B5.1. Activists emphasise import of broad public support<br>B5.2. Key constituencies criticise 'inappropriate' violence                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |

# summarising logics of restraint - (Busher et al. 2021 and Ravndal 2020)

(‘ascending the **ladder of abstraction**, Sartori 1970)

1. A **strategic logic** (violence is counterproductive in the present circumstances)
2. A **moral logic** (certain forms of violence are illegitimate)
3. A **logic of ego maintenance** (we are not a violent organization)
4. A **logic of outgroup definition** (softening views on putative outgroups)
5. An **organisational logic** (the organisation evolves in ways that undermine the logics of violent escalation)

# summarising logics of escalation - Busher et al. (2017)

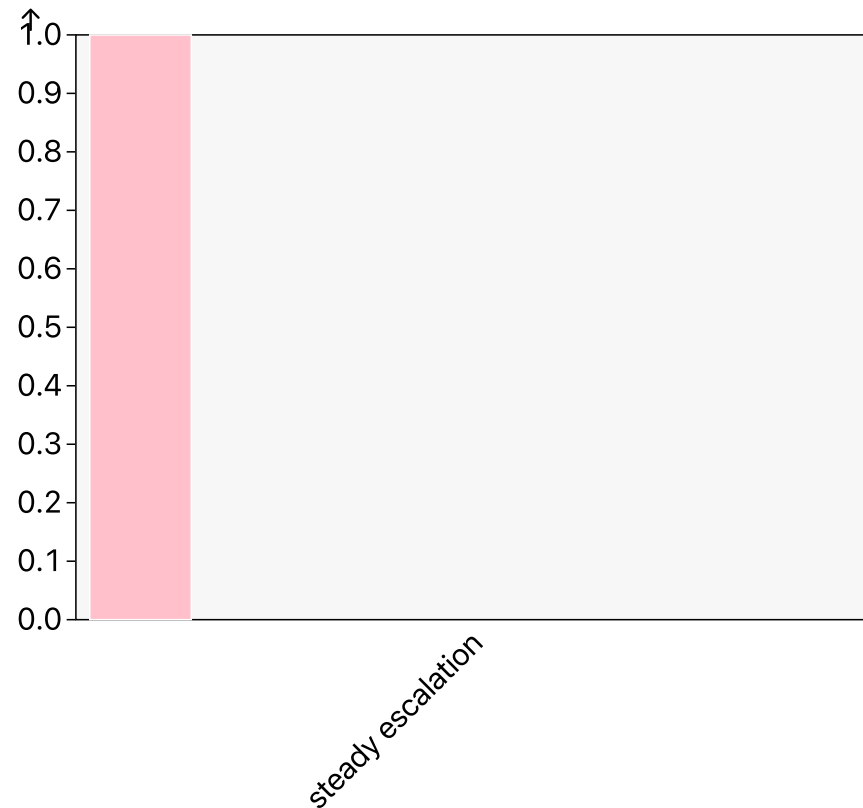
(‘ascending the **ladder of abstraction**, Sartori 1970)

1. **framing logic** (intensity of context/threat, revolutionary goals, glorification of violence, violence as viable/necessary, increasing vilification of ‘enemies’)
2. **strategic logic** (cope with changing dynamics with opponents and/or state, deal with diminishing opportunity, loss of state control)
3. **organisational logic** (declining moderate influence, logistical/practical preparation for violence)
4. **constituency/social logic** (endorsement/legitimation from elites and/or public, politics/media focuses on radical flank)

# Group responses - violence over time

How does the group's use of violence evolve over time?

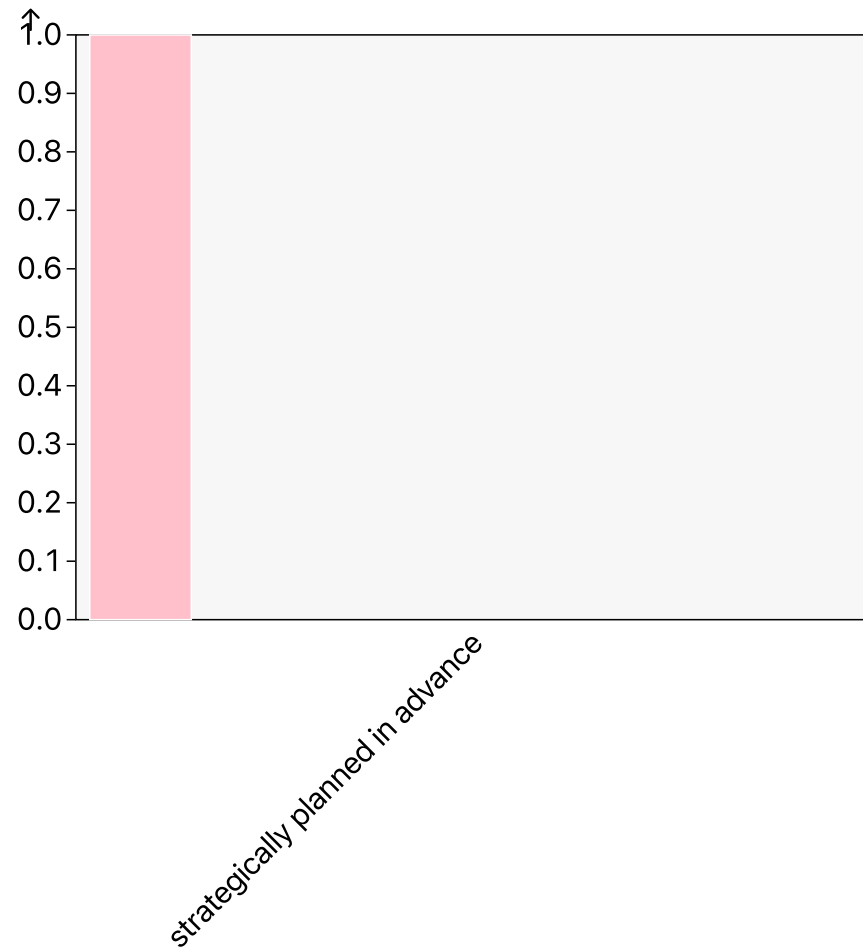
Antifa RAF IS alQaeda NPD/Heimat NSU PKK



# Group responses - characteristic violence

Major acts of violence are typically...

Antifa RAF IS alQaeda NPD/Heimat NSU PKK





# Group responses - restraint

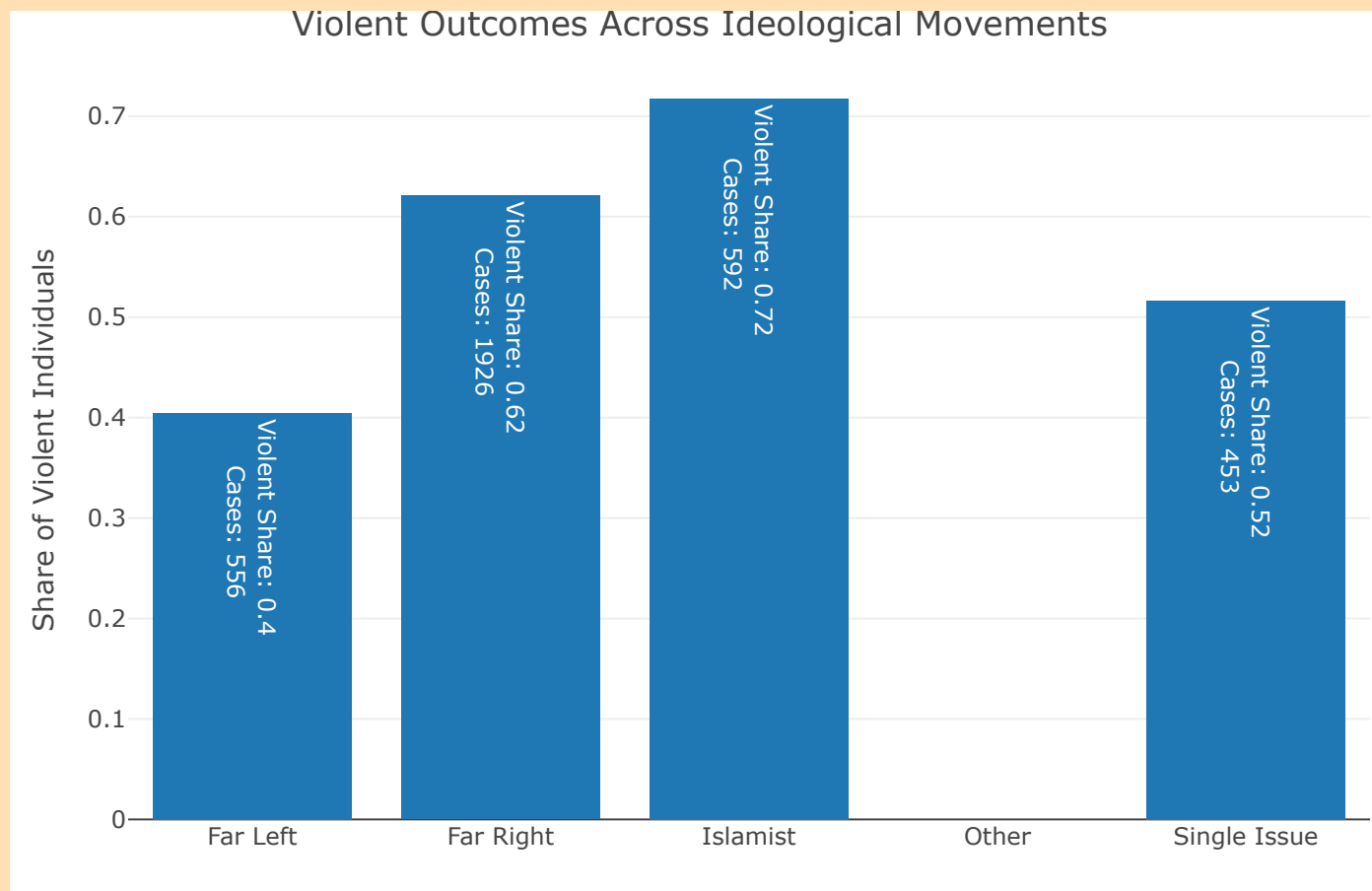
# Group responses - breaks and accelerators

# Open data - Profiles of Radicalisation

Visualisation

Explanatory note

Data table



# A case of RWE restraint?

- Nordic Resistance Movement (NRM) at a glance
- Tore Bjørgo on NRM
  - findings



# NRM at a glance

# Nordic Resistance Movement (NRM) - Tore Bjørgo



**Tore Bjørgo** on Why the Nordic Resistance Movement Restrains its Use of Violence ([Bjørgo and Ravndal 2020](#))

# Nordic Resistance Movement (NRM) - Tore Bjørgo



# 1. *When, why does NRM permit use of violence?*

- no **moral restraints**, rather **violence perceived as courageous and productive** (to gaining support and freely propagating views)
- try to **expand boundaries of acceptable violence** with acts against police and political enemies

# 2. *Why, how does NRM restrain use of violence?*

- to maintain **strategic position**
- commit members to **maintaining nonviolent discipline**

# 3. *How does NRM leadership respond to cases where members overstep and act violently?*

- **honouring** rather than **punishing** activists who overstep
- **BUT ALSO distancing** from any affiliation or connection



# Any questions, concerns, feedback for this class?

Anonymous feedback here:

<https://forms.gle/NfF1pCfYMbkAT3WP6>

Alternatively, please send me an email: [m.zeller@lmu.de](mailto:m.zeller@lmu.de)

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**Questions about groups next meeting:** (1) Does the group try to grow its popular support? (2) Does the group's violence increase local support for it? (3) What type of participation does the group most rely on? (4) Do most civilians in areas where the group is active support the group? (5) Does the group provide services (security, justice, welfare) that generate legitimacy?

# References

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